VIRTUALEXPERT.NET

The AI-Ready VA

The course and certification for virtual assistants who want to set up and run AI for the businesses they support

DENISE CULLOM

Welcome

For more than 25 years I ran operations for coaching, consulting, SaaS and digital businesses. As COO of a business coaching company, I helped grow revenue from about $5 million to $16 million while keeping 35% net profit margins, with a team of more than 50 people. A lot of that team was remote, and some of the best people on it were assistants who started out answering email and ended up running whole parts of the business.

The assistants who moved up all had one thing in common. They didn't wait to be told how to do something better. They noticed the work that repeated, wrote down how it should be done, and found a faster way to do it. That's exactly the skill AI rewards.

Right now, most small business owners know AI could save them hours a week. Very few have the time to figure out how. They don't need a developer or an expensive consultant. They need someone who already knows their business, their inbox, their clients and their tools, and who can set AI up safely and keep it running. That's you.

This course teaches you to become that person. By the end, you'll be able to:

- Use Claude or ChatGPT to do your own client work faster and better.
- Find the work in a client's business that AI should take over, and put a dollar figure on it.
- Build, test and document AI workflows that run every week, with clear rules on what a person must check.
- Protect your clients' data and your own reputation while you do it.
- Package all of this as a service, price it on value, and pitch it to the clients you already have.

How this course works

There are eight modules. Each one has short lessons, a **Do it now** exercise, and a **Check yourself** quiz. Work through them in order. Most people finish in two to three weeks at a few hours a week.

- **Modules 1 to 3** are the foundations: what changes in your role, how the tools work, and how to handle client data safely.
- **Modules 4 to 6** are the hands-on core: find the opportunities, build the workflows, then document and maintain them.
- **Module 7** turns your new skills into income.
- **Module 8** is your final project and how to earn your certification.

The course comes with a **templates pack** (agreements, audit forms, workflow cards, SOPs, proposals, pitch scripts and a prompt library) and the **AI-Ready VA Toolkit** spreadsheet, which scores tasks, calculates savings and works out your prices. You'll use all three as you go.

How to earn your certification

Complete the final project in Module 8: build one real AI workflow for a client (or a practice business), measure it, document it and write a short case study. Then take the online assessment and submit your project from the certification page linked on your download page. Pass both and you'll receive your **AI-Ready VA** certificate and badge to use on your website, LinkedIn profile and proposals.

The one rule

AI drafts. People approve. Nothing AI writes goes to a customer, a bank, a public page or an employee until a person has read it. Early on, that person is you. Later, for some workflows, it can be your client. You can loosen this rule one workflow at a time once it has earned trust (Module 6 shows how), but every workflow starts on a short leash. Follow this rule and you will never be the VA whose AI sent the wrong thing to the wrong person.

Module 1: From assistant to AI operator

Lesson 1.1: What's actually changing

AI is very good at the kind of work a lot of VAs are paid to do: first drafts of emails, summaries of meetings, sorting an inbox, formatting documents, researching a list of prospects, turning notes into a social post. Some VAs see that and worry. The better way to see it is this: the tasks are getting cheaper, but the person who knows *which* tasks to hand to AI, how to set it up, and how to check it is getting more valuable.

Your clients don't want to learn prompt writing, compare tools, read data policies or fix a workflow when it breaks. They want the work done well, on time, without risk. If you can deliver that with AI doing the heavy lifting, you can take on more clients, charge for outcomes instead of hours, and become the person they can't imagine running the business without.

Lesson 1.2: The three levels of AI service

Think of your AI skills as three levels. Each one is worth more than the last.

Level	What you do	How clients pay
1. AI-powered assistant	You use AI to do your normal tasks faster and better. The client sees better work, sooner.	Your usual rate, but you deliver more in the same hours, or keep more margin on fixed-price work.
2. AI workflow builder	You find the client's repetitive work, build AI workflows for it, and document them.	A one-time setup fee per workflow or a setup package.
3. AI operations partner	You run, check, improve and report on the client's AI workflows every month.	A monthly retainer, priced on the hours and money the workflows save.

Most VAs today sit at level 1 without realizing it, because they use AI for their own work but never tell the client. This course moves you to levels 2 and 3, where the real money is.

Lesson 1.3: The mindset shift: own the outcome, not the task

A task-based VA hears "can you write the newsletter every week?" and writes the newsletter every week. An AI operator hears the same request and asks: where do the ideas come from, what does a good one look like, who approves it, what does it link to, and how do we know it's working? Then they build a workflow that produces a strong draft every Tuesday, check it, and send it for approval.

Three habits make the shift:

1. **Notice repetition.** Anything you do more than twice a month is a candidate.

2. **Write it down.** If you can't describe the steps, AI can't follow them either.
3. **Measure it.** Know how long the task took before and after. That number is what you'll sell.

Lesson 1.4: Be honest about AI with your clients

Some VAs quietly use AI and bill as if they did everything by hand. Don't. It's a trust problem waiting to happen, and it keeps you stuck at level 1. Instead, make AI part of your offer: "I use AI tools to work faster, and I check everything before it reaches you or your customers." Clients who are nervous about AI usually relax when they hear there's a clear process and a person accountable for it. Module 3 gives you a simple written agreement for this.

Do it now: Your AI starting point

1. List every task you did for clients in the last two weeks. Aim for at least 20.
2. Mark each one: **A** if you already use AI for it, **B** if AI could clearly help, **C** if it needs a human (judgment, relationships, live calls).
3. Count your B's. That's your first opportunity list. Keep it; you'll use it in Module 4.

Check yourself: Module 1

1. Which level of AI service is usually paid as a monthly retainer?
2. What are the three habits of an AI operator?
3. Why is quietly using AI without telling a client a risk?

Answers: (1) Level 3, AI operations partner. (2) Notice repetition, write it down, measure it. (3) It damages trust if they find out, and it keeps you paid by the hour for work AI is doing, instead of selling the value you're creating.

Module 2: AI foundations for VAs

If you already use Claude or ChatGPT every day, skim Lessons 2.1 and 2.2 and focus on 2.3 to 2.6. Those are the parts most people skip, and they're what separate a VA who "uses ChatGPT" from one who runs AI for a business.

Lesson 2.1: The tools, in plain English

Claude (made by Anthropic) and **ChatGPT** (made by OpenAI) are general AI assistants. You type a request in plain English and they read, write, summarize, analyze and research. Both can work with files you upload and with apps you connect, like email, calendar and cloud drives. For a VA, either one will do everything in this course.

Many of your clients will also have AI built into tools they already pay for, such as **Microsoft Copilot** in Microsoft 365 or **Gemini** in Google Workspace. Those are worth using when the client's documents and email already live there, because the data doesn't need to leave their system. The skills in this course work the same way in any of them: clear instructions, the right information, and a person checking the result.

Pick **one** main tool to learn deeply first. You can learn a second one when a client needs it.

Lesson 2.2: Whose account is it?

This is the single most important setup decision, and most VAs get it wrong.

- **Your own work** (your marketing, your admin, your proposals): use your own account.
- **Client work that touches their data** (their inbox, customers, finances, files): use an account the **client owns and pays for**, with you added as a user. Business and team plans make this easy.

Why it matters: if the workflows live in your personal account, the client's data is sitting in your account, the client loses everything if you part ways, and you carry the risk if something goes wrong. When the client owns the account, they own their data, their workflows, and the setup they paid you to build. That's more professional, and it makes your work easier to sell, because nobody worries about being held hostage.

For clients on a budget, a single paid seat on a business plan in the client's name is enough to start.

Lesson 2.3: How to write a request that works

Most bad AI output comes from vague requests. Use the **five-part request** every time it matters:

1. **Role:** who should the AI act as? ("You are the office manager for a three-person accounting firm.")
2. **Context:** what does it need to know? (the client, the audience, the situation, the files attached)
3. **Task:** exactly what to produce, with a verb. ("Draft a reply to this email...")

4. **Format:** length, structure, tone. ("Under 120 words, friendly, sign off 'Best, Maria.'")
5. **Check:** what it must not do and what to flag. ("Don't promise dates. If you're not sure of a fact, write [CHECK] instead of guessing.")

> **Example: weak vs strong**
>
> Weak: "Write a reply to this customer."
>
> Strong: "You handle customer email for Bright Smiles Dental, a family dental practice in Austin. Draft a reply to the email below. The patient wants to move their cleaning to next week. We have openings Tuesday at 10am and Thursday at 3pm. Keep it under 80 words, warm and simple, signed 'The Bright Smiles team.' Don't confirm a booking; offer the two times and ask them to reply with their choice. If they mention pain or an emergency, write [URGENT: CALL PATIENT] at the top instead of a reply."

The strong version takes 60 seconds longer to write and saves you rewriting the reply three times. Once you have a request that works, you save it and never write it again. That's the start of a workflow.

Lesson 2.4: Projects: give the AI a memory for each client

Both Claude and ChatGPT have **projects**: a dedicated space with its own standing instructions and files. Everything you ask inside the project uses those instructions and files automatically.

For each client, create at least one project, named clearly (for example, "Bright Smiles: Customer Email"). Inside it:

- **Instructions:** who the client is, what they sell, who their customers are, their tone of voice, the rules (what never to say or do), and what to flag for a person.
- **Files:** the reference material a good assistant would need: FAQ, price list, service descriptions, a few emails that show the client's voice, policies, brand guide.

A project with good instructions and files turns a generic AI into one that knows the business. Lesson 5.1 gives you the full template.

Lesson 2.5: Connectors and scheduled tasks: from chat to workflow

Two features turn AI from a chat window into something that runs work.

Connectors (called Apps in ChatGPT) let the AI read and sometimes write in tools like Gmail, Outlook, Google Calendar, Google Drive, Notion and Slack. With the inbox connected, "summarize what came in overnight" works without you pasting anything.

Scheduled tasks let you give the AI a job that runs on a timetable: every weekday at 7am, every Monday, the first of each month. You write the task once and it delivers a result on schedule for you to review.

Rules for both:

- **Connect only what the workflow needs.** A newsletter workflow doesn't need the client's bank.
- **Start read-only.** Let the AI read and draft before you ever let it send, post or change anything.
- **Write scheduled tasks so they can run without you.** Say exactly what to read, what to produce, where to put it, and what it must never do. A task that would ask you a question halfway through will fail when nobody is there to answer.

Tools change fast. Features get renamed, moved between plans or retired (for example, OpenAI is retiring custom GPTs in December 2026 in favor of projects). Build your workflows on the basics, instructions, files, connectors and schedules, and they'll survive these changes. When a feature you rely on changes, Module 6 shows you how to move a workflow without starting over.

Lesson 2.6: Check everything: the 60-second review

AI can state wrong things with total confidence. Before anything leaves your hands, run the 60-second review:

1. **Facts:** names, dates, prices, numbers, links. Are they right, and did they come from the client's information rather than the AI's guess?
2. **Promises:** does it commit the client to anything (a refund, a date, a discount) they haven't approved?
3. **Tone:** does it sound like the client, not like a robot?
4. **Privacy:** does it include anything that shouldn't go to this person?
5. **Flags:** did the AI leave any [CHECK] or [NEEDS ANSWER] markers that need resolving?

Do it now: Build your first client project

1. Pick one client (or invent a practice business if you don't have one yet).
2. Create a project in Claude or ChatGPT named "[Client]: General Assistant."
3. Write instructions with all five parts: who the client is, their customers, their tone, the rules, what to flag.
4. Upload two or three reference files: an FAQ, a service list, a few emails in their voice.
5. Ask it to draft three real tasks from your week. Run the 60-second review on each and note what you had to fix. Add a rule to the instructions for anything you fixed twice.

Check yourself: Module 2

1. Whose account should hold workflows that use a client's customer data?
2. Name the five parts of a strong request.
3. What's the safest way to start a new connector?
4. Why must a scheduled task never need to ask you a question?

Answers: (1) An account the client owns, with you added as a user. (2) Role, context, task, format, check. (3) Read-only: let the AI read and draft before it can send, post or change anything. (4) It runs when nobody is there to answer, so it will stall or guess.

Module 3: Working safely with client data

Clients trust you with their inbox, their customers, sometimes their finances. One careless paste can undo years of that trust. This module is short, but it's the one clients care about most, and knowing it cold is a selling point.

This module is practical guidance, not legal advice. If a client works in a regulated field such as healthcare, finance, legal or anything involving children's data, they should check with their own adviser before you connect AI to that data.

Lesson 3.1: Know what never goes in

Unless the client has approved it in writing and the account is set up for it, never paste or upload:

- Passwords, login codes, API keys or security questions.
- Full card numbers, bank account numbers, tax ID or Social Security numbers.
- Medical or health information about any person.
- Anything the client has called confidential, such as legal matters, HR issues, salaries, or deals in progress.
- Other people's personal details beyond what the task needs.

When a task needs sensitive material, **strip it first**. Replace names with roles ("Customer A"), remove account numbers, summarize instead of pasting the whole document. The AI almost never needs the sensitive part to do the job.

Lesson 3.2: Set the account up properly

For every account that handles client work, check these settings with the client:

1. **Training on data:** business and team plans of the major tools generally don't use your content to train their models by default. On personal plans there's usually a setting for this. Check it and record what it's set to.
2. **Who has access:** you, the client, and anyone else they choose. Use your own login, never a shared one.
3. **Two-step login:** turn it on for every account.
4. **Connectors:** list each one, what it can access, and whether it can only read or can also send and change things.
5. **History and memory:** know where the AI stores chats and memory, and how to delete them if the client asks.

Settings and plan names change, so check the current help pages for the tool rather than relying on memory, and re-check every few months.

Lesson 3.3: Put it in writing: the AI use agreement

Before you connect AI to anything of the client's, agree on the rules in writing. It protects both of you and it shows the client you take this seriously. The templates pack includes a one-page **AI Use Agreement** you can adapt. It covers:

- Which AI tools you'll use and whose account they run in.
- What data AI may and may not see.
- What AI may do on its own (usually: read and draft) and what always needs a person (send, post, pay, delete).
- Who reviews what before it goes out.
- What happens to the data, workflows and account if you stop working together (they stay with the client).
- How either of you can pause or switch off any workflow.

Lesson 3.4: When something goes wrong

Sooner or later, an AI draft will contain a wrong fact or a reply will go to the wrong person. What makes you a professional is how you handle it:

1. **Stop the workflow** (pause the scheduled task or disconnect the connector).
2. **Tell the client the same day**, plainly: what happened, who was affected, what you've done.
3. **Fix the cause:** a missing rule, a wrong file, too much access, a check that was skipped.
4. **Write it down** in the workflow's change log (Module 6), so it doesn't happen again.

Do it now: Your data rules

1. Open the AI Use Agreement in the templates pack and fill it in for one client.
2. Open the AI account you'll use for that client and check the five settings in Lesson 3.2. Record each one on the agreement.
3. Write your personal "never paste" list, based on the kind of clients you work with, and keep it next to your desk.

Check yourself: Module 3

1. Name three kinds of information you should never paste into an AI tool without written approval.
2. What should you do with a document that contains sensitive details but is needed for a task?
3. What are the first two steps when an AI workflow makes a mistake that reaches someone?

Answers: (1) Any three of: passwords or login codes, card or bank numbers, tax or Social Security numbers, health information, confidential legal, HR, salary or deal information, unnecessary personal details. (2) Strip or replace the sensitive parts, or summarize it, before using it. (3) Stop the workflow, then tell the client the same day.

Module 4: Find the AI opportunities in a client's business

The VAs who earn the most from AI don't start with tools. They start with the client's week. This module gives you a simple audit you can run in about an hour, plus a way to put a dollar figure on what you find.

Lesson 4.1: The task inventory

List every recurring task in the area you support. Go through these sources so nothing hides:

- **Your own time log** or invoices for the last month.
- **The client's calendar:** recurring meetings usually have prep and follow-up work around them.
- **The inbox:** what kinds of email come in again and again?
- **The tools:** what gets updated weekly in the CRM, spreadsheet, project board or accounting software?
- **The client's complaints:** "I spend every Sunday night on..." is gold.

For each task, write down: what it is, who does it, how often, and roughly how long it takes each time. The **Task Audit** tab of the toolkit spreadsheet is set up for this.

Lesson 4.2: Score each task

Not every task should go to AI. Score each one from 1 to 3 on five questions. The toolkit adds up the score for you.

Question	1 point	2 points	3 points
How often?	Monthly or less	Weekly	Daily
How long?	Under 15 minutes a time	15 to 60 minutes	Over an hour
How predictable?	Different every time	Mostly the same steps	Same steps, same kind of input
Is the information available?	Lives in people's heads	Partly written down	In files or tools AI can reach
How low is the risk if a draft is wrong?	High (money, legal, health)	Medium (customers see it after review)	Low (internal only)

Tasks scoring **12 or more** are your best first workflows. Tasks scoring **9 to 11** are good later candidates. Under 9, leave them alone for now.

Lesson 4.3: Interview the person who does the work

The task list tells you *what*. A 20-minute conversation tells you *how*, and that's what AI needs. For each high-scoring task, ask:

1. Walk me through the last time you did this, step by step.
2. Where does the information come from?
3. What does a great result look like? Can you show me one?
4. What usually goes wrong?
5. What decisions do you make along the way, and how do you decide?
6. Who sees the result, and what do they do with it?
7. What would you never want to happen?
8. How long does it really take, including the interruptions?

Record the answers in the **AI Opportunity Audit** form in the templates pack. Those answers become the instructions for the workflow, almost word for word.

Lesson 4.4: Put a price on each task

Clients buy outcomes they can measure. For each top task, work out:

Hours saved per month = (minutes before − minutes after, including review) × times per month ÷ 60

Value per month = hours saved × the hourly cost of whoever does it now

Be honest about "after." A workflow that cuts a two-hour report to 30 minutes of review saves 90 minutes, not two hours. And use the real cost of the person doing it now: if it's the business owner, their time is often worth far more than your rate, which makes the case even stronger.

> **Example: a weekly client report**
>
> Before: the owner spends 2 hours every Friday pulling numbers and writing the client report. After: an AI workflow drafts it from the project board, and the owner spends 20 minutes reviewing it.
>
> 100 minutes saved × 4 weeks = **6.7 hours a month**. At the owner's time valued at $100/hour, that's **$667 a month** freed up, or about $8,000 a year, from one workflow.

The **Savings & ROI** tab of the toolkit does this math for you.

Lesson 4.5: Pick the first three

From your scored list, pick three workflows to build first:

- **One quick win:** high score, low risk, you can build it this week. It earns trust.
- **One big saver:** the biggest monthly value on the list. It makes the business case.
- **One the client will notice:** something that removes a task they personally hate. It makes them a fan.

Write the three on the **Audit summary** at the end of the AI Opportunity Audit form and share it with the client. This one page is often what turns into your first paid AI project.

Do it now: Run a mini audit

1. Using your B list from Module 1, plus your client's calendar and inbox, list at least 15 recurring tasks in the toolkit's Task Audit tab.
2. Score them all.
3. Interview yourself or the client on the top three, using the eight questions.
4. Work out the monthly hours and value for each in the Savings & ROI tab.
5. Pick your quick win, big saver and the one they'll notice.

Check yourself: Module 4

1. What five things do you score each task on?
2. A task scores 13. What should you do with it?
3. A task took 90 minutes, now takes 15 minutes of review, and happens 8 times a month. How many hours a month does it save?

Answers: (1) How often, how long, how predictable, whether the information is available, and how low the risk is. (2) Treat it as one of the best candidates for a first workflow. (3) 75 minutes × 8 = 600 minutes, or 10 hours a month.

Module 5: Build workflows that run every week

A **workflow** is a task AI does the same way every time, with standing instructions, the right files, access to the right tools, and a clear check by a person. This module gives you the recipe and eight workflows almost every small business needs. Build two or three for your own practice or a client before moving on.

Lesson 5.1: The workflow recipe

Every workflow has the same six parts. Write them on a **Workflow Card** (in the templates pack) before you build anything.

1. **Job:** one sentence on what it produces. ("A draft reply to every routine customer email, every weekday morning.")
2. **Instructions:** the standing rules, using the five-part request from Module 2.
3. **Files:** the reference material it needs.
4. **Connections:** which tools it can read, and whether it can write.
5. **Trigger:** on request, or on a schedule (when?).
6. **Check:** who reviews the result, what they look for, and what it must never do.

Then build it as a project, test it on five real examples, fix the instructions, and only then put it on a schedule.

> **Template: Workflow instructions**
>
> You are [role] for [client business], which [one line on what they do and for whom].
>
> **Your job:** [what this workflow produces, how often].
>
> **Use these files:** [list each file and what it's for, e.g., "FAQ.pdf for answers to common questions"].
>
> **Voice:** [three rules, e.g., "warm, short sentences, no exclamation marks, sign off 'Thanks, the [Business] team'"].
>
> **Always:** [2 to 4 must-dos, e.g., "include the customer's name," "link to the booking page"].
>
> **Never:** [hard limits, e.g., "promise refunds," "give medical advice," "send anything; drafts only"].
>
> **When unsure:** write [CHECK: your question] instead of guessing.
>
> **Deliver:** [format, e.g., "a numbered list of drafts, each with the sender and subject on top"].

Lesson 5.2: Eight workflows every small business needs

Each of these takes 30 to 90 minutes to set up. The prompts below are starting points; replace every [bracket] with the client's real details.

Workflow 1: Morning inbox triage

Saves: 20 to 40 minutes a day · **Needs:** email connector · **Runs:** weekdays before the client starts work

> **Scheduled task: Morning inbox triage** · Weekdays, 7:00am
>
> Read the emails in [client]'s inbox from the last 24 hours (72 on Mondays). Sort them into: Needs [client] today (clients, money, deadlines, decisions), Can wait, and Ignore (newsletters, promotions, notifications). Always flag anything from [VIP senders] or mentioning [keywords]. For routine emails, draft a reply in [client]'s voice using the FAQ file, and save it as a draft. If you don't know the answer, write [NEEDS ANSWER] in the draft. Deliver a summary with the "today" list first, one line each: who, what, deadline. Never send, delete or archive any email.

Check: you read every draft for the first two weeks. Add a rule each time you fix the same thing twice.

Workflow 2: Meeting prep and follow-up

Saves: 15 to 30 minutes per meeting · **Needs:** calendar, email, and a notes or transcript tool

> **Prompt: Meeting prep brief**
>
> Using [client]'s calendar, find tomorrow's external meetings. For each, write a short brief: who they're meeting (name, company, role), our history with them from email in the last 90 days, any open items or promises, and three suggested talking points. Keep each brief under 150 words.
>
> **Prompt: Meeting follow-up**
>
> Here are the notes or transcript from [client]'s meeting with [name]. Write: (1) a five-bullet summary, (2) a list of action items with owner and due date, and (3) a follow-up email from [client] to [name] confirming next steps, under 150 words, in [client]'s voice. Mark anything you're unsure of with [CHECK].

Workflow 3: SOP writer

Saves: 1 to 3 hours per procedure · **Needs:** a screen recording transcript, rough notes or a voice memo

Prompt: Turn notes into an SOP

You write clear standard operating procedures for [client business]. Turn the notes below into an SOP with: a title, the purpose in one sentence, when it's done and by whom, what's needed before starting, numbered steps (one action per step, starting with a verb), what "done" looks like, and common mistakes to avoid. Use plain language a new hire could follow on day one. Where a step is unclear, write [ASK: question] instead of guessing.

This one quietly makes you indispensable: every SOP you write is a business asset the client now owns, and it's the foundation for automating that process later.

Workflow 4: Content repurposing

Saves: 2 to 4 hours a week · **Needs:** the client's long-form content (blog, podcast, video transcript, newsletter)

Prompt: One piece, many posts

You write social content for [client], who helps [audience] with [problem]. From the content below, write: 3 LinkedIn posts (different angles, 120 to 200 words, each opening with a strong first line), 5 short posts for [other platform], and one email newsletter intro of 100 words. Use [client]'s voice from the samples file. Don't invent statistics or client results that aren't in the source. End each post with [suggested image idea].

Workflow 5: Customer support drafts

Saves: 30 to 60 minutes a day for a busy inbox · **Needs:** FAQ, policies, product or service info

Instructions: Support reply drafter

You draft replies to customer questions for [business]. Use only the FAQ, policies and product files provided. Answer clearly in under 120 words, warmly, signed "[sign-off]." If the answer isn't in the files, write [NEEDS ANSWER: question] and draft only a polite holding reply. Flag at the top: any complaint, refund or cancellation request, legal threat, or mention of injury or health. Never offer discounts, refunds or exceptions; a person decides those.

Workflow 6: Bookkeeping prep

Saves: 1 to 3 hours a month · **Needs:** exported transactions (with account numbers removed) and the client's category list

Prompt: Categorize transactions

Here is a list of transactions and [client]'s chart of account categories. Assign each transaction a category. Put your answer in a table with: date, description, amount, category, and confidence (high, medium, low). List every low-confidence item at the bottom with the question you'd ask the client. Also list: any charge that appears to be a duplicate, any subscription that renews this month, and any amount over [$ threshold]. Do not change any amounts.

Check: the client or their bookkeeper approves categories before anything is entered into the accounting software. You prepare; a qualified person decides.

Workflow 7: Research briefs

Saves: 1 to 2 hours per brief · **Needs:** web search turned on

Prompt: Research brief

Research [topic, company or person] for [client], who needs it to [purpose: e.g., prepare for a sales call, choose a vendor]. Give: a three-sentence summary, the five most useful facts with a source link for each, any red flags, and three questions [client] should ask. Only include facts you can link to a source. If sources disagree, say so.

Check: click every link. If a fact has no working source, delete it.

Workflow 8: Weekly report

Saves: 1 to 2 hours a week · **Needs:** access to the project board, CRM or spreadsheet the report draws from

Scheduled task: Weekly report · Fridays, 2:00pm

Read [source: e.g., the project board and this week's sales sheet]. Write [client]'s weekly report: (1) wins this week, (2) numbers compared with last week ([list metrics]), (3) what's behind and why, (4) decisions needed from [client], (5) next week's priorities. Keep it to one page. Use only numbers from the sources; if a number is missing, write [MISSING: what]. Deliver as a draft document for review. Don't send it to anyone.

Lesson 5.3: Test before you trust

Before a workflow goes on a schedule:

1. **Run it on five real examples**, including one messy or unusual one.
2. **Score each result:** usable as is, needs light edits, or needs a rewrite.
3. **Fix the instructions,** not the output. Every rewrite means a rule is missing.
4. **Repeat** until four out of five are usable with light edits.
5. **Time it:** how long does review take now? That's your real "after" number.

Lesson 5.4: Earn autonomy in stages

Every workflow climbs the same ladder, one rung at a time:

Stage	What AI does	What a person does
1. Draft	Produces drafts	Reviews and edits everything
2. Review	Produces finished work	Checks before it's used
3. Spot-check	Produces and files the work	Reviews a sample each week
4. Exceptions	Handles routine cases end to end	Handles only what it flags

Move up only after two to four weeks without a significant fix, and only with the client's written OK. Anything involving money, legal commitments, health, or public statements stays at stage 1 or 2. Permanently.

Do it now: Build your quick win

1. Take the quick win from your Module 4 audit.
2. Fill in a Workflow Card for it.
3. Build it as a project with instructions and files.
4. Test it on five real examples and fix the instructions until four of five are usable.
5. Record your before-and-after time.

Check yourself: Module 5

1. What are the six parts of every workflow?
2. A draft comes out wrong. Should you fix the draft or the instructions?
3. What's the test for "ready to schedule"?
4. Which kinds of work never go past stage 2 on the autonomy ladder?

Answers: (1) Job, instructions, files, connections, trigger, check. (2) Both, but the lasting fix is in the instructions, so the mistake doesn't repeat. (3) Four out of five real examples are usable with light edits. (4) Anything involving money, legal commitments, health, or public statements.

Module 6: Document, hand off and maintain

A workflow that only you understand is a liability. A workflow that's documented, measured and maintained is an asset, and maintenance is what turns one-time setup fees into monthly income.

Lesson 6.1: Document every workflow

Each workflow gets a one-page **Workflow Card** (you started it in Module 5) and an **SOP** for the person who reviews it. Store both in a shared folder the client owns, named so anyone can find them: "AI Workflows / 01 Inbox triage / Workflow card," and so on.

The SOP covers:

- Where the workflow lives (which account, which project).
- When it runs and where the result appears.
- How to review it, step by step, including the 60-second review.
- What to do if it fails or produces something wrong.
- How to pause it.

The templates pack has both templates. The test: could someone else on the client's team run this workflow if you were on vacation for two weeks?

Lesson 6.2: The change log

Every time you change a workflow's instructions, files or access, write a one-line entry: date, what changed, why. This takes 20 seconds and saves hours when something stops working, because you can see exactly what changed and when. It's also proof of the ongoing work you do on a retainer.

Lesson 6.3: The monthly maintenance check

Once a month, for each workflow:

1. **Is it still running?** Check the last four results arrived on time.
2. **Is it still good?** Read a sample. Are edits creeping up?
3. **Is the information current?** Prices, policies, team members, products and FAQs go out of date. Update the files.
4. **Has the tool changed?** Features get renamed, moved or retired. Check for announcements from the tool's maker.
5. **Is access still right?** Remove connectors and people who no longer need them.
6. **What did it save?** Update the hours-saved figure in the toolkit.

Lesson 6.4: When the tool changes

AI tools change constantly. When a feature you depend on is retired or a client switches tools:

1. Your workflow card already holds everything that matters: job, instructions, files, connections, trigger, check.
2. Rebuild it in the new tool or feature using the same card.
3. Run the five-example test again before switching it on.
4. Note the move in the change log.

This is exactly why you build on instructions and files, not on one tool's special features. The card is portable; the setup is just the current home.

Lesson 6.5: The monthly AI report

Send every client a short monthly report. It's the single best way to keep a retainer, because it makes your value visible. Keep it to one page:

- **Hours saved this month,** per workflow and in total, with the dollar value.
- **What we improved** (from the change log).
- **Issues and fixes,** honestly.
- **Next opportunity:** one new workflow you recommend, with its estimated savings.

The template is in the templates pack. That last line is how retainers grow.

Do it now: Make it handoff-ready

1. Finish the Workflow Card and write the SOP for the workflow you built in Module 5.
2. Start its change log.
3. Draft a first monthly AI report for that client, even if it only covers one workflow.

Check yourself: Module 6

1. What's the test for whether a workflow is properly documented?
2. Name four things you check in the monthly maintenance check.
3. Why should every monthly report end with a "next opportunity"?

Answers: (1) Someone else could run it if you were away for two weeks. (2) Any four of: still running, still good, information current, tool changes, access still right, savings updated. (3) It shows the client where more value is and is how retainers grow.

Module 7: Package, price and sell your AI services

You now have skills most of your competitors don't. This module turns them into offers clients can say yes to.

Lesson 7.1: Your three offers

Keep it simple. Three offers cover almost every client:

Offer	What's included	How to price it
AI Opportunity Audit	The Module 4 audit: task inventory, scoring, interviews, top three workflows with savings. One-page summary and a call.	Fixed fee. Often credited toward setup if they go ahead.
AI Setup Sprint	Build, test and document two or three workflows over two to four weeks, including the AI Use Agreement, workflow cards, SOPs and training for the client.	Fixed fee per sprint, priced on value (Lesson 7.2).
AI Operations Retainer	Monthly: run and review the workflows, the maintenance check, the monthly report, and one improvement or new workflow per month.	Monthly fee, on top of or bundled with your regular VA work.

The audit gets you in the door, the sprint proves the value, and the retainer is your steady income.

Lesson 7.2: Price on value, not hours

If you price AI work by the hour, you get paid less the better you get. Price on what the client gains instead.

1. Work out the **monthly value** of the workflows (Module 4).
2. Set the **setup fee** at roughly **one to three months** of that value. Clients easily say yes to something that pays for itself within a quarter.
3. Set the **retainer** at roughly **15% to 30%** of the ongoing monthly value, with a floor that covers your time comfortably.

Example

Three workflows save the client 18 hours a month. At $50/hour for the people doing that work now, that's $900 a month in value.

Setup sprint: 1.5 × $900 = **about $1,350**. Retainer: 25% of $900 = **about $225 a month**, which you might round to $250 to include the monthly report and one improvement.

The client keeps about $650 a month after paying you, and gets it every month.

Use the **Pricing** tab in the toolkit to run these numbers for each client. Then sanity-check against your own time: if the setup will take you 15 hours, make sure the price is well above 15 times your hourly rate. If it isn't, the workflow isn't worth enough yet, or you need to choose bigger ones.

Lesson 7.3: Start with the clients you already have

Your current clients are your easiest sale: they trust you, you know their business, and you've already seen where the time goes. Use this message (the full set of scripts is in the templates pack):

Script: Offer an AI audit to a current client

Hi [name], I've been training in setting up AI workflows for small businesses, and while working on your [area] I spotted a few places where AI could save you real time, for example [one specific task you noticed] which I think could go from [X] to [Y] a week. Would you be open to me doing a short AI audit of your [area]? I'd map where the time goes, show you the top three things worth automating with what each would save, and you can decide from there. It takes me about [time] and costs [price], which I'd credit toward setting anything up if you go ahead.

Then hold a 20-minute call, run the audit, and present the one-page summary with the three workflows, their savings and your sprint price. Lead with their numbers, not with AI.

Lesson 7.4: Win new clients with proof

Once you've done one sprint, you have what new clients want most: proof.

- **Write a case study** of every workflow you build (the template is in the pack): the problem, what you built, hours saved, what the client said. Anonymize it if needed.
- **Update your profiles.** Change your headline from "Virtual Assistant" to something like "AI-ready virtual assistant: I set up and run AI workflows that save small businesses hours every week."
- **Show your certification badge** on your website, LinkedIn and proposals once you've earned it in Module 8.
- **Post what you build.** A short post each week on a workflow you set up, and the time it saved, attracts exactly the clients you want.

Lesson 7.5: Handle the common objections

- **"Isn't AI risky?"** "It can be, which is why I set it up with a written agreement, in an account you own, and nothing goes out without a person checking it."
- **"Can't I just do this myself?"** "You can. Most owners don't have the 20 to 40 hours it takes to learn, set up and test it. I've already done that."
- **"Will this replace you?"** "It replaces the repetitive parts of my work, so I can spend your hours on the things that need judgment."
- **"It's too expensive."** "Based on the audit, it saves you about [$value] a month, so it pays for itself in [months]. Let's start with the one workflow that saves the most."

Do it now: Your first offer

1. Use the toolkit Pricing tab to price an audit, a sprint and a retainer for one real client.
2. Fill in the AI Services Menu in the templates pack.
3. Send the audit offer script to one current client this week.
4. Update your profile headline.

Check yourself: Module 7

1. What are the three offers, and what's each one's job?
2. Workflows save a client $1,200 a month. What's a reasonable range for the setup fee?
3. What should you lead with in an AI pitch?

Answers: (1) Audit gets you in the door, sprint proves the value, retainer creates steady income. (2) Roughly $1,200 to $3,600, one to three months of value. (3) The client's own numbers, the time and money saved, not the technology.

Module 8: Your final project and certification

This is where you prove you can do it. The certification means something because it's based on real work, not just a quiz.

The final project

Build one AI workflow for a real client, or for a realistic practice business if you don't have a client who's ready. Then submit these five items:

1. **The audit.** Your task inventory and scoring for at least 10 tasks, with the top three chosen and the reason for each.
2. **The Workflow Card** for the workflow you built: job, instructions, files, connections, trigger and check.
3. **Test results.** The five-example test: how each result scored and what you changed in the instructions.
4. **The savings.** Before and after time, hours saved per month and the monthly value, with your assumptions.
5. **A short case study** (150 to 300 words) written as if for your website, plus a note on how you protected the client's data.

Remove client names and anything confidential before you submit. Change names to "Client A" if you need to.

How it's assessed

Area	What a pass looks like
Opportunity	The workflow was chosen from a scored list for a clear reason.
Build	The instructions are specific, include voice, rules, "never" limits and what to flag.
Safety	Data handling is thought through: the right account, minimal access, no sensitive data pasted, a person checks before anything goes out.
Testing	Five real examples, with the instructions improved based on what went wrong.
Value	Savings are calculated honestly, with review time included.
Communication	The case study is clear enough for a business owner to understand and want.

How to submit

1. Go to the **certification page** linked on your download page.
2. Take the online assessment: 15 questions drawn from the eight modules. You need 12 correct to pass, and you can retake it.
3. Once you pass, the project submission form opens. Paste or link your five items.
4. Your project is reviewed within about seven business days. If anything needs work, you'll get specific feedback and can resubmit as many times as you need.

Your certificate and badge

When your project passes, you'll receive:

- Your **AI-Ready VA certificate** (PDF) with your name, date and certificate number.
- Your **AI-Ready VA badge** to use on your website, LinkedIn profile, email signature and proposals.

Using the badge well: put it next to a line that says what it means, such as "Certified AI-Ready VA: trained to set up and run AI workflows safely for small businesses." Use it only for yourself, not for a team, and don't change its design.

What to do next

- **Run your first paid audit** within 30 days, while it's fresh.
- **Build a case study** from every workflow you set up.
- **Keep learning.** Tools change monthly. Re-read Module 6 every quarter and review your clients' workflows against it.
- **Get more ideas.** *20 AI Agents That Pay for Themselves* (at virtualexpert.net/agents) has 20 more ready-to-build workflows with the savings math for each, and every one is a service you can sell.

Congratulations on getting this far. You're not just an assistant who uses AI. You're the person a business trusts to run it.

Quick reference

The five-part request

Role · Context · Task · Format · Check

The six parts of a workflow

Job · Instructions · Files · Connections · Trigger · Check

The 60-second review

Facts · Promises · Tone · Privacy · Flags

The scoring rule

Score 1 to 3 on frequency, time, predictability, available information and low risk. 12 or more: build first. 9 to 11: later. Under 9: leave it.

The savings formula

Hours saved per month = (minutes before − minutes after, including review) × times per month ÷ 60. Value = hours saved × hourly cost of whoever does it now.

The pricing rule

Setup: one to three months of value. Retainer: 15% to 30% of monthly value, with a floor that covers your time.

The one rule

AI drafts. People approve.